

USC CUTS SPENDING AMID FEDERAL PROBES

The university plans hiring freeze and more as it faces deficit and ‘funding uncertainty.’

By DANIEL MILLER AND JAWEED KALEEM

Roiled by multiple investigations from the Trump administration, USC has announced a slate of cutbacks — including a staff hiring freeze — as it braces for what it called “federal funding uncertainty” in a letter released Monday.

Among the nine austerity measures are a reassessment of capital spending projects and restrictions on discretionary spending, according to the letter signed by university leaders including outgoing President Carol Folt.

The USC actions come at a time of unprecedented threats against universities by the Trump administration. It has vowed to cut federal funding — including key medical and science research grants — to institutions that do not comply with its directives. Trump has ordered campuses to squelch antisemitism; eliminate diversity, equity and inclusion programs; and ban transgender athletes from competing in women’s sports.

“Recent developments require us to take additional steps to increase our financial resilience in the face of exceptional financial uncertainty,” said the letter, which noted that USC received about \$570 million in research funding in fiscal year [See USC, A5]



Photographs by MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

DEAN WENNER looks at the rubble on Pacific Coast Highway where his house stood before the Palisades fire. He is eager to rebuild.

Trying to rebuild beside a rising sea



ENVIRONMENTAL advocates have favored a policy of “managed retreat” from imperiled shorelines. But fire victims resist the idea.

Malibu properties face many climate risks. Should burned homes be replaced?

By James Rainey

Dean and Denise Wenner were sweet on the Cape Cod-style home from the moment they found it in 2019. It had five bedrooms spread over three levels, with decks that hung over Santa Monica Bay.

When the tide was up, you felt almost like you were on an ocean liner, with views that swept from Palos Verdes to Point Dume.

Now the Wenners are among more than 300 families along Pacific Coast Highway in Malibu who lost their homes in the January firestorms, all of them facing even greater hurdles than their inland neighbors in trying to rebuild homes that most never planned to

leave.

The reason for extra anxiety along Pacific Coast Highway? The very qualities that made the houses so special — their precarious toehold on the Pacific coast — will now make them particularly challenging to rebuild.

Already burned by a fire that came from the north and east, the owners are being required to rebuild their homes to ward off ever-rising seas and fiercer storms coming from the south and west.

That will mean not just incorporating the fireproofing measures now required of homes throughout [See Coastal, A6]

Why a polystyrene ban hasn’t worked

California prohibits styrofoam in food service items. How is it still on the shelves?

By SUSANNE RUST

Styrofoam coffee cups, plates, clamshell takeout containers and other food service items made with expanded polystyrene plastic can still be found in restaurants and on store shelves, despite a ban that went into effect on Jan. 1.

A Smart and Final in Redwood City was brimming with foam plates, bowls and cups for sale on a recent visit. Want to buy these goods online? It was

no problem to log on to Amazon.com to find a variety of foam food ware products — Dart insulated hot/cold foam cups, or Hefty Everyday 10.25-inch plates — that could be shipped to an address in California.

Same with the restaurant supply shop KaTom, which is based in Kodak, Tenn.

Smart and Final and KaTom didn’t respond to requests for comment. A spokesperson for Amazon said the company would look into the matter.

The expanded polystyrene ban is part of a single-use plastic law, Senate Bill 54, that Gov. Gavin Newsom signed into law in 2022 but bailed on earlier this month. [See Plastics, A6]



WILLIAM LIANG For The Times

SEA LIONS at a San Pedro rescue center. A surge in marine mammals sickened by domoic acid, a neurotoxin, has prompted warnings to beachgoers to steer clear.

Toxic algae bloom takes toll on marine mammals

By SUMMER LIN

Sea lions and other ocean mammals in Southern California are falling victim to a poisoning event that a local expert calls the worst in recent memory. It is stranding the mammals along the coast as warnings are issued to beachgoers of the threat posed by animals that are transformed by their illness.

A surfer reported an attack by a sea lion that was “feral, almost demonic” as he was on his board off

Ventura County on Friday. Rj LaMendola said the animal bit him as he surfed off Oxnard, shaking its head and dragging him off his surfboard. He said on Facebook that as he paddled away terrified, the sea lion continued to stalk him.

LaMendola, who has been surfing in Oxnard since 2006, said he tried to splash the sea lion to scare it away. He later contacted the Channel Islands Marine & Wildlife Institute, who told him the attack likely happened due to the toxic algae

bloom.

“It was super intense,” he said, “unlike anything I’ve ever seen in all the years I’ve been in the water.”

Ingesting domoic acid from harmful algal blooms can cause sea lions to have seizures or to crane their heads in a motion known as “stargazing.” They can also fall into a comatose state. But experts advise people not to interact with animals believed to be sick because, without warning, they might aggressively lunge or even [See Mammals, A9]

Trump discounts security breach

He calls the texting of sensitive war plans on the publicly available Signal app a ‘glitch.’

By DAVID KLEPPER AND AAMER MADHANI

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Tuesday downplayed the texting of sensitive plans for a military strike against Yemen’s Houthis this month to a group chat that included a journalist, saying it was “the only glitch in two months” of his latest administration as Democratic lawmakers heaped criticism on officials for handling highly sensitive information carelessly.

Trump told NBC News that the lapse “turned out not to be a serious one,” and articulated his continued support for national security [See Signal, A5]

Is messaging app Signal safe to use?

Cybersecurity experts weigh in on whether the app is for everyday communication. **NATION, A5**

Star’s injury dims USC’s title hopes

Losing JuJu Watkins for the rest of the season could prove devastating, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Inside the O.C.’s ghost town mall

Kaleidoscope offers its very few visitors broken elevators and sewage smells. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly cloudy. L.A. Basin: 72/53. **B6**

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‘No Other Land’ co-director hurt

Palestinian Hamdan Ballal is released after attack and detention. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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